

Sources for the Prelude The Blind Advance

*A compilation of primary source documents on the opening of the Gettysburg Campaign, June
1863*

This document collects the primary sources referenced in “The Road to Gettysburg: How Two Armies Marched North Blind,” Part 1 of the Echo & Chronicle Gettysburg series. All texts below are taken verbatim from official reports and correspondence written by the participants themselves in 1863, reproduced here in full or in relevant excerpt for reference. Original sources and citations are noted at the head of each document.

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I. Official Report of General Robert E. Lee

Headquarters, Army of Northern Virginia, July 31, 1863, and January 1864 (excerpts). Official Records, Series I, Vol. 27, Part 2. Source: Gettysburg National Military Park, National Park Service (nps.gov).

The position occupied by the enemy opposite Fredericksburg being one in which he could not be attacked to advantage, it was determined to draw him from it. The execution of this purpose embraced the relief of the Shenandoah Valley from the troops that had occupied the lower part of it during the winter and spring, and, if practicable, the transfer of the scene of hostilities north of the Potomac. It was thought that the corresponding movements on the part of the enemy to which those contemplated by us would probably give rise, might offer a fair opportunity to strike a blow at the army then commanded by General Hooker, and that in any event that army would be compelled to leave Virginia, and, possibly, to draw to its support troops designed to operate against other parts of the country.

No report had been received that the Federal Army had crossed the Potomac, and the absence of the cavalry rendered it impossible to obtain accurate information. ... Preparations were now made to advance upon Harrisburg; but, on the night of the 28th, information was received from a scout that the Federal Army, having crossed the Potomac, was advancing northward, and that the head of the column had reached the South Mountain. As our communications with the Potomac were thus menaced, it was resolved to prevent his farther progress in that direction by concentrating our army on the east of the mountains. Accordingly, Longstreet and Hill were directed to proceed from Chambersburg to Gettysburg, to which point General Ewell was also instructed to march from Carlisle.

The movements of the army preceding the battle of Gettysburg had been much embarrassed by the absence of the cavalry. ... In the exercise of the discretion given him when Longstreet and Hill marched into Maryland, General Stuart determined to pass around the rear of the Federal Army with three brigades and cross the Potomac between it and Washington, believing that he would thus be able, by that route, to place himself on our right flank in time to keep us properly advised of the enemy's movements.

R. E. LEE, General.

II. Robert E. Lee to J.E.B. Stuart

Headquarters, Army of Northern Virginia, June 23, 1863, 5 p.m. Official Records, Series I, Vol. 27, Part 3, p. 923. Source: Lee Family Digital Archive, Stratford Hall (leefamilyarchive.org). Transcribed by Colin Woodward, 2016.

Maj. Gen. J. E. B. Stuart, Commanding Cavalry:

General: Your notes of 9 and 10.30 a.m. to-day have just been received. ... If General Hooker's army remains inactive, you can leave two brigades to watch him, and withdraw with the three others, but should he not appear to be moving northward, I think you had better withdraw this side of the mountain to-morrow night, cross at Shepherdstown next day, and move over to Fredericktown.

You will, however, be able to judge whether you can pass around their army without hinderance, doing them all the damage you can, and cross the river east of the mountains. In either case, after crossing the river, you must move on and feel the right of Ewell's troops, collecting information, provisions, &c.

Give instructions to the commander of the brigades left behind, to watch the flank and rear of the army, and (in the event of the enemy leaving their front) retire from the mountains west of the Shenandoah, leaving sufficient pickets to guard the passes, and bringing everything clean along the Valley, closing upon the rear of the army. ... I think the sooner you cross into Maryland, after to-morrow, the better.

Be watchful and circumspect in all your movements.

I am, very respectfully and truly, yours,

R. E. LEE, General.

III. General Order Assuming Command

Headquarters of the Army of the Potomac, June 28, 1863. Source: American Battlefield Trust (battlefields.org).

Note: this order is numbered General Order No. 66 by this source; some other citations number it No. 67, with No. 66 attributed to Hooker's farewell order of the same date. The text of Meade's order itself is consistent across sources.

By direction of the President of the United States, I hereby assume the command of the Army of the Potomac. As a soldier, in obeying this order, an order totally unexpected and unsolicited, I have no promises or pledges to make. The country looks to this army to relieve it from the devastation and disgrace of a hostile invasion. Whatever fatigues and sacrifices we may be called upon to undergo, let us have in view constantly the magnitude of the interests involved, and let each man determine to do his duty, leaving to an all-controlling Providence the decision of the contest.

It is with just diffidence that I relieve, in the command of this army, an eminent and accomplished soldier, whose name must ever appear conspicuous in the history of its achievements; but I rely upon the hearty support of my companions in arms to assist me in the discharge of the duties of the important trust which has been confided to me.

GEORGE G. MEADE, Major-General Commanding

IV. Official Report of Brigadier General John Buford (excerpt)

Headquarters First Cavalry Division, August 27, 1863 (covering June 27–July 31). Official Records, Series I, Vol. 27, Part 1, pp. 926–928. Source: The Portal to Texas History, University of North Texas Libraries (texashistory.unt.edu).

June 29, the Reserve Brigade was detached and moved to Mechanicstown. The First and Second Brigades moved through Boonsborough, Cavetown, and Monterey Springs, and encamped near Fairfield, within a short distance of a considerable force of the enemy's infantry. ... The whole community seemed stampeded, and afraid to speak or to act, often offering as excuses for not showing some little enterprise, "The rebels will destroy our houses if we tell anything."

June 30, the two brigades moved out very early to go to Gettysburg, via Fairfield. ... I immediately turned my column toward Emmitsburg without serious molestation, and was soon on my proper road and moving on Gettysburg ... We entered Gettysburg in the afternoon, just in time to meet the enemy entering the town, and in good season to drive him back before his getting a foothold. He withdrew toward Cashtown, leaving his pickets about 4½ miles from Gettysburg.

The night of the 30th was a busy night for the division. No reliable information of value could be obtained from the inhabitants, and but for the untiring exertions of many different scouting parties, information of the enemy's whereabouts and movements could not have been gained in time to prevent him from getting the town before our army could get up. By daylight on July 1, I had gained positive information of the enemy's position and movements, and my arrangements were made for entertaining him until General Reynolds could reach the scene.

JNO. BUFORD, Brigadier-General of Volunteers,
Commanding.

V. Official Report of Major General Henry Heth (excerpt)

Official Records, Series I, Vol. 27, Part 2. Source: Gettysburg National Military Park, National Park Service (nps.gov).

On reaching the suburbs of Gettysburg, General Pettigrew found a large force of cavalry near the town, supported by an infantry force. Under these circumstances, he did not deem it advisable to enter the town, and returned, as directed, to Cashtown. The result of General Pettigrew's observations was reported to Lieutenant-General Hill, who reached Cashtown on the evening of the 30th.

On July 1, my division, accompanied by Pegram's battalion of artillery, was ordered to move at 5 a.m. in the direction of Gettysburg. On nearing Gettysburg, it was evident that the enemy was in the vicinity of the town in some force. It may not be improper to remark that at this time—9 o'clock on the morning of July 1—I was ignorant what force was at or near Gettysburg, and supposed it consisted of cavalry, most probably supported by a brigade or two of infantry.

Note: this report makes no mention of shoes as the object of Pettigrew's reconnaissance; it states only that he was sent, per Lee's own report, to procure supplies. The widely repeated "shoes" detail originates from Heth's postwar memoir, written decades after the battle, not from his 1863 official report reproduced above.